growing power of the Planning Commission—responsible for Five Year Plans—in the years immediately following Independence, believing that the body's efforts were not accountable and marginalized the elected government. [10] While these debates progressed, India's per capita incomes increased about 2 per cent annually throughout the 1950s after almost no per capita growth in the first forty-seven years of the twentieth century under British colonial rule.

The third element of independent India's initial policy orientation—concerning foreign policy—was informed primarily by Non-Alignment, a notion articulated by Nehru before Independence, including in an address to All India Radio on 7 September 1946.

> We [the Interim National Government] shall take full part in international conferences as a free nation with our own policy and not merely as a satellite of another nation. We hope to develop close and direct contacts with other nations and to cooperate with them in the furtherance of world peace and freedom. We propose, as far as possible, to keep away from the power politics of groups, aligned against each other, which have led in the past to world wars and which may again lead to disasters on an even vaster scale. We believe that peace and freedom are indivisible and the denial of freedom anywhere must endanger freedom everywhere and lead to conflict and war. We are particularly interested in the emancipation of colonial and dependent countries and peoples, and in the recognition in theory and practice of equal opportunities for all races . . . We seek no dominion over others and we claim no privileged position over other peoples. But we do claim equal and honourable treatment for our people wherever they may go, and we cannot accept any discrimination against them. [11]

In that same speech, Nehru went on to call for 'friendly and co-operative relations' with Britain and the Commonwealth, recognized the 'major role in international affairs' played by the United States and warned that India would have 'to undertake many common tasks' with the Soviet Union. He highlighted that Indians were 'of Asia and the peoples of Asia are nearer and closer to us than others' and that India was 'the pivot of Western, Southern and South-East Asia'. Finally, he hoped that China 'that mighty country with a mighty past' would emerge as 'a united and democratic China'. [12] China was then in the midst of a civil war but was led by the Chinese Nationalist Party or Kuomintang (KMT) under Chiang Kai-Shek.